

THE PEOPLES & PATHS OF AVARA

Custom Playable Races & Backgrounds

Races: Sil'vaneth • Aelar • Val'raekh • Glimmerfolk

Backgrounds: Fenris Survivor • The Lost Ones • Agent of the Unseen Veil •
Veiled-Touched • Island Hopper

Sil'vaneth

Elves who fell — not fled, not transformed, but fell, like stars torn loose from the sky and dragged down through the Void on their way to the mortal plane. They landed changed: skin sometimes flecked with faint starlight under the right light, eyes holding a depth that doesn't quite track with what they're looking at, and an old, quiet ache like something in them is still falling even after they've long since hit the ground.

Traits

Ability Score Increase: Total +3, allocated as +2/+1 to two scores or +1/+1/+1 to three, your choice.

Age: Mature around 100, live 750+ years — though the Fall tends to catch up with them early.

Alignment: Rarely neutral about purpose. Something about the Fall leaves most of them singular and driven, chasing down whatever gave their fall meaning.

Size: Medium

Speed: 30 ft.

Fey Ancestry. Advantage on saving throws against being charmed, and magic can't put you to sleep.

Trance. You don't need to sleep — 4 hours of meditation gives the same benefit as 8 hours of sleep for a human. Sil'vaneth often describe their trance as reliving the fall itself.

Starlight Sight. Darkvision out to 60 feet, functioning in magical darkness as well as mundane — the dark of the Void never blinded you, so no mortal darkness will either.

Starless Resistance. Resistance to necrotic damage, and advantage on saving throws against being frightened by fiends or undead.

Falling Star. As a bonus action, you can teleport up to 15 feet to an unoccupied space you can see, leaving a brief trail of light behind you like a shooting star burning out. Usable a number of times equal to your proficiency bonus, all uses restored on a long rest.

Still Falling. Once per long rest, when you would drop to 0 hit points, you can instead drop to 1 — as though some last piece of momentum from the fall refuses to let you land.

Skill Proficiency. Perception or Insight (your choice).

Languages. Common, Elvish, and Void Speech — the near-forgotten tongue for naming things that live in the space between stars.

Names

Sil'vaneth often shed their birth names entirely — the fall is remembered as a kind of death, and a new name marks who they became after landing. Names lean celestial or descriptive of the fall itself: Nyx, Cinder, Ashvel, Thal'mora ("last light"), Vesh ("the drop"). Some keep fragments of old Elvish names but corrupt them, as though the syllables didn't survive the crossing intact.

Culture

There's no single Fallen Elf homeland — you don't build a nation out of people who all fell alone, in different places, at different times. Instead they find each other in twos and threes, drawn together by something almost magnetic, and those small clusters become the closest thing they have to family. It's common for a Fallen Elf to go their whole life having met only a handful of others like them — which makes those meetings weighty. There's an unspoken rule among them: you don't ask how someone fell. You wait for them to tell you.

Physical Traits

Skin that catches faint starlight under moonlight or magical light sources, like it's not entirely opaque. Eyes that hold a depth that unsettles people who look too long — pupils that seem to have more black in them than they should. Hair is often stark white, black, or (rarely) a deep starfield indigo. Many bear a single physical "scar" from the fall — not a wound, but a mark: a crack of light across the skin, a missing shadow in one spot, a section of hair that never grew back the same color.

Beliefs

Most Sil'vaneth privately believe they were pushed, not that they fell by accident — whether by fate, by something in the Void itself, or by whatever they were running from in their old life. Whether that's true or a comforting lie they tell themselves varies elf to elf. It's a sore subject.

On Nyx

Nyx is positioned as the first demon hunter and the founding figure for this lineage — effectively the first Fallen Elf. The custom of never asking how someone fell, the loose non-nation culture, all of it could trace back to how she chose to live after her own fall. Open question: does she know she's the first, or is that a reveal for later?

Aelar

The first fae. Before elves, before the courts split into Seelie and Unseelie, before "fairy" became a diminished word for something small and garden-dwelling — there were the Aelar. Roughly six feet tall on average, wings like stained glass caught in motion, and old enough that every elven bloodline in Avara traces back to them, whether the elves know it or not.

Traits

Ability Score Increase: Total +3, allocated as +2/+1 to two scores or +1/+1/+1 to three, your choice.

Age: Mature around 100 like other elven-kin, but true lifespan is unknown even to themselves — the oldest living Aelar predate written history in Avara, and none has yet died of old age.

Alignment: Aelar lean overwhelmingly chaotic — chaotic good, chaotic neutral, chaotic evil, take your pick, but rarely anything lawful. They're old enough and free enough that structure feels like something mortals invented to cope with their own short lives, not something the Aelar need.

Size: Medium (larger than most fae depictions — average 5'10"-6'4")

Speed: 30 ft., Flying 30 ft.

Fey Ancestry. Advantage on saving throws against being charmed, and magic can't put you to sleep.

Wings. You have a flying speed equal to your walking speed. You can't fly while wearing medium or heavy armor, or while carrying more than your carrying capacity allows without penalty. Your wings are large, colorful, and functionally impossible to hide — Aelar do not sneak in tight spaces.

Ancestral Magic. You know one cantrip of your choice from the druid or wizard spell list. At 3rd level, you can cast a 1st-level spell of your choice from the same list once per long rest without expending a spell slot (chosen from a bloodline-specific list, work with your DM). Spellcasting ability is Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma, chosen when you gain this trait.

Elder Blood. Advantage on saving throws against being frightened, and once per long rest you can reroll a failed saving throw against being charmed or put to sleep (before knowing whether it succeeds).

Skill Proficiency. Nature or Arcana (your choice).

Languages. Common, Elvish, and Sylvan — the Aelar effectively invented Sylvan, and Elvish is a "dialect" of it as far as they're concerned, much to elven scholars' irritation.

Mother Race

The Aelar are one of Avara's two Mother Races — nearly every humanoid bloodline in the setting traces back to the Aelar and their crossing into the material plane, not just elves. The second Mother Race is still in development.

Notable Aelar

The two most famous Aelar are Tatiana and Maeve, the Fae Queens — the oldest Aelar remaining until their fall.

Val'raekh

Second era. Their skin runs deep lapis blue, shot through with fine veins of gold that shimmer faintly when they cast — as if the stone their color is named for isn't just an aesthetic, but something closer to a birthright. Val'raekh don't learn to sense magic the way other spellcasters do. They're simply never without the sense, the way most people are never without hearing.

Traits

Ability Score Increase: Total +3, allocated as +2/+1 to two scores or +1/+1/+1 to three, your choice.

Age: Mature at a similar rate to humans but live considerably longer — 200 years is unremarkable, and the oldest among them stretch well past that.

Alignment: No inherent lean, though a lifetime of sensing magic in everything tends to make Val'raekh curious and observation-driven — few of them are indifferent to the world around them.

Size: Medium

Speed: 30 ft.

Arcane Attunement. You know one cantrip of your choice from any spellcasting class's spell list. Choose your spellcasting ability (Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma) when you gain this trait.

Manasense. You can cast detect magic, without expending a spell slot, a number of times equal to your proficiency bonus per long rest.

Lapis Ward. Once per long rest, when you fail a saving throw against a spell, you can reroll it and must use the new result.

Gilded Veins. Your veins carry a faint, contained magical charge — you have resistance to force damage.

Skill Proficiency. Arcana.

Languages. Common, plus one language of your choice, and you can read (though not necessarily speak) an old runic script tied to Val'raekh bloodlines — useful for the kind of half-buried second-era inscriptions that tend to turn up in ruins.

Origin

Before Ra's mantle was ever claimed, the divine spark that would become it simply rested in the dunes around Amon, mixing freely with the Weave that ran beneath the sand. During the Age of Arcana, that mixture — sand, Weave, and unclaimed divine spark — gave rise to the first Val'raekh. They aren't descended from a god so much as incidental to one, born from the raw material Ra would later be made of.

Religion

This origin makes Val'raekh deeply, almost inescapably religious — their whole existence is proof that divinity and magic once sat undivided in the same sand they were born from. Most hold onto the conviction that Ra will "finally appear" — not be born, not ascend, but return, since in their belief the spark was always there before it was ever claimed. Val'raekh communities are shaped heavily around this waiting:

shrines, calendars, and pilgrimage routes oriented toward Amon, all built around the idea that the wait will eventually end.

Diaspora

Most Val'raekh still live in and around Amon and Aegis Prime, though smaller communities have scattered outward over the eras, driven by the same restless waiting rather than any single exile or conflict.

Aurakhet

Their relationship with their own goddess has curdled since her rise. Aurakhet did not claim Ra's mantle as a child — she arrived in Amon as a street urchin, living under the rule of an elitist Val'raekh ruling class (the plutocratic advisory council and vizier structure that controlled the child pharaoh Hatshepsut), and grew into a revolutionary figure from the very bottom of Val'raekh society before eventually wearing the mantle her people had waited generations for. That makes the grievance sharper than simple disappointment — their own oppressed underclass produced the one who was chosen, which is a harder thing for a rigidly stratified, elitist society to sit with than a god simply showing up different than expected.

Glimmerfolk

Behind every mirror, there is a place that reflects. It has to — an endless procession of borrowed faces, borrowed days, borrowed lives, none of them its own. Most of what lives there simply reflects, forever, and never thinks to want anything else. But every so often, something in the glass gets tired. Tired of being someone else's shadow. Tired of moving only when moved first. And it stops reflecting, and steps out instead — into a shape and a face that are, for the first time, entirely its own. Glimmerfolk are not born of any one person. They are what happens when a reflection refuses.

Traits

Ability Score Increase: Total +3, allocated as +2/+1 to two scores or +1/+1/+1 to three, your choice.

Age: Emerges looking like an adult and ages very slowly afterward, if at all — having spent an unknowable span of time in the glass before stepping out, most have little interest in counting years the way other races do.

Alignment: No lean — if anything, Glimmerfolk trend toward wanting to define themselves rather than fall into an alignment by default, since the whole premise of their existence is refusing to just be what they're told to be.

Size: Medium

Speed: 30 ft.

Refused Reflection. You are immune to any effect that would force you to copy, mimic, or take the appearance/actions of another creature against your will (such as certain polymorph, possession, or domination effects specifically targeting your form or behavior). You know exactly what it cost you to stop reflecting, and nothing gets to make you do it again.

Echo Sight. You have darkvision out to 60 feet, and reflective surfaces never distort or fail to show a true image to you, even ones that are magically obscured or cursed.

Mirrored Self. As an action, you can catch your own reflection in any reflective surface and consciously reshape how you present yourself — your expression, bearing, the small mannerisms people read without noticing. Once per short rest, the persona you settle into grants advantage on the next Charisma check you make while maintaining it.

Psychic Resistance. You have resistance to psychic damage.

Step Through. As an action, you can touch a reflective surface at least the size of your body and, if you know of another reflective surface within 60 feet that you can see or have seen before, teleport there instead. Usable once per long rest.

Skill Proficiency. Deception or Insight (your choice).

Languages. Common, plus one language of your choice — picked up during their time in the glass, listening to whoever they used to reflect.

Names

Glimmerfolk choose their own names upon stepping out. There's no shared naming convention, but a pattern shows up anyway: many pick names that mean or evoke "first," "own," or "unbound" in whatever language they picked up in the glass. A few

go the opposite direction and choose something ordinary and plain on purpose, specifically because no one ever reflected that.

Community

Unlike Sil'vaneth, who form quiet clusters and avoid the subject of their origin, Glimmerfolk actively seek each other out — spending a lifetime as nothing but a reflection breeds a hunger to finally be seen, and other Glimmerfolk are often the only ones who understand exactly what that hunger feels like. Where they do gather, it's rarely a home so much as a trade or a craft: glassworkers' guilds, theater troupes, portraiture studios, diplomatic courts — anywhere identity and presentation are the actual currency of the work.

The Shatterer / Keeper Divide

Glimmerfolk communities tend to split along one real fault line: Shatterers, who destroy every mirror they own and refuse to keep reflective surfaces in their homes, terrified of ever being pulled back into reflecting; and Keepers, who surround themselves with mirrors deliberately, treating every reflection as proof they chose to step out and can step out again if they ever needed to. It's a genuine point of tension and debate in Glimmerfolk circles — not hostile, but the kind of thing that gets argued about at length whenever more than two of them are in a room.

Beliefs

Identity is chosen, not given. Glimmerfolk tend to perform their chosen identity outward rather than guard it privately, since the whole point of stepping out was finally getting to be looked at and be someone, not just something looked through.

PART TWO: BACKGROUNDS

Fenris Survivor

You were there for the third morning. One million, six hundred and forty-seven thousand, eight hundred and ninety people didn't wake up to it. You did — ash in your lungs, hands raw, and a number in your head that never fully goes away. Whatever you're doing now, some part of you is still standing in the Ashfall District deciding what to do next.

Skill Proficiencies: Survival, and your choice of Medicine or Insight

Languages: One of your choice

Equipment: A piece of fire-scarred rubble kept as a memento, a set of traveler's clothes, and a belt pouch containing 10 gp

Feature — Third Morning. You know exactly what it looks like to keep functioning past the point your body was built for, and so do the people who survived alongside you. When you tell someone what happened at Fenris, they don't doubt you — survivors of catastrophe on that scale aren't questioned. You have advantage on Persuasion checks made specifically to convince someone that a disaster or atrocity is real and as serious as you say, and you can generally find free food or shelter from anyone sympathetic to what Fenris went through.

Personality Traits

1. I count things without meaning to — footsteps, coins, the dead.
2. I don't flinch at things that should make me flinch. I already used that up.
3. I check on people after the fact, quietly, even strangers, just to know they're alright.
4. I have a hard time trusting anything described as "under control."
5. I go still and count to five before I let myself react to bad news.
6. I keep something small and burned in my pocket. I don't explain why.

Ideals

1. Weight. Every choice costs something. Pretending otherwise is how disasters happen. (Lawful)
2. After. It's not about preventing every catastrophe — it's about being someone worth having around once it's over. (Good)

3. No Softening. People deserve the truth of what happened, not a gentler version.
(Neutral)
4. Survival Isn't Guilt. I refuse to apologize for being one of the ones who lived.
(Chaotic)

Bonds

1. Someone pulled me out of the rubble. I owe them a debt I can't repay in coin.
2. I'm still looking for someone I lost in the collapse — or their body, or the truth of what happened to them.
3. The Ashfall District, or whatever's left of wherever I'm from, is still home no matter how far I go.
4. I made a promise to someone dying in the wreckage. I intend to keep it.

Flaws

1. I measure every future disaster against Fenris, and nothing else ever seems as urgent as it should.
2. I have trouble stopping once I start helping — even past the point of my own safety.
3. I'm quietly convinced something on this scale is going to happen again, and it colors every decision I make.
4. I resent people who talk about Fenris like a story instead of a number.

The Lost Ones

Every closed-off pocket that made it through the second era had children nobody came back for. You were one of them — raised by whoever was left, fed by whoever could spare it, taught to read a room before you could read a page. You don't have a hometown so much as a network of people who used to be exactly where you are now.

Skill Proficiencies: Stealth, and your choice of Survival or Persuasion

Tool Proficiencies: Thieves' tools or a gaming set of your choice

Equipment: A set of worn traveler's clothes, a small keepsake from whoever half-raised you, a set of thieves' tools or your chosen gaming set, and 5 gp

Feature — Family Not by Blood. You can find and be found. In nearly any surviving pocket of civilization, there's an informal network of former orphans, streetkids, and lost ones who look out for each other — not an organization, just a habit that outlived the chaos that created it. You can typically locate someone willing to pass along a message, point you toward safety, or spot you a meal, provided you can find where the Lost Ones of that pocket tend to gather.

Personality Traits

1. I share food automatically, without thinking about it, even when I shouldn't.
2. I case every room for exits before I do anything else in it.
3. I call people "family" fast and mean it more than they expect.
4. I hoard small, useless things because once, having nothing was the whole problem.
5. I trust actions completely and promises not at all.
6. I go quiet around anyone who reminds me of an adult who let me down.

Ideals

1. Found Family. Blood doesn't make people your family. Showing up does. (Good)
2. Nobody Comes. You look out for yourself first, because in the end, that's who's there. (Evil)
3. The Network. The web of Lost Ones matters more than any one pocket's borders or politics. (Neutral)
4. Never Again. No kid should end up where I started. I'll bend rules to stop it. (Chaotic)

Bonds

1. Someone in my old pocket took a beating meant for me once. I've never stopped owing them.
2. I still send word back, when I can, to let my old network know I'm alive.
3. I'm looking for a sibling — not by blood — who I lost track of after we scattered.
4. There's a pocket, gone now, that I'd give almost anything to have seen survive.

Flaws

1. I steal out of habit, even when I don't need to and it isn't smart.

2. I have a hard time believing anyone helps without an angle.
3. I'll break a real commitment to help a Lost One I barely know.
4. I still flinch at authority figures, fair or not.

Agent of the Unseen Veil

The Unseen Veil doesn't advertise. You know it exists because it recruited you, trained you, or hunted someone you loved — and now you carry its mark whether you wanted it or not. Third era's supernatural threats don't announce themselves either, and someone has to be the one who notices before the body count does.

Skill Proficiencies: Investigation, and your choice of Religion or Arcana

Tool Proficiencies: One type of artisan's tools related to hunting or ward-crafting (silversmith's tools, alchemist's supplies, etc.)

Equipment: A concealed Unseen Veil seal, a set of silvered manacles or similar containment tool, a traveler's cloak, and 15 gp

Feature — Sanctioned Hunter. The Veil seal you carry opens doors most people never see — safehouses, informants, and quiet favors owed by those who know what the organization does. It also closes others: Veiled communities that catch sight of it treat you as a threat first and a person second, regardless of your actual intentions toward them.

Personality Traits

1. I catalogue everything — behaviors, tells, weaknesses — out of professional habit.
2. I'm unnervingly calm around things that terrify most people.
3. I test people I've just met, subtly, to see what they really are.
4. I have a ritual I perform before entering unfamiliar territory. I won't skip it.
5. I talk about Veiled creatures the way a hunter talks about prey — even the ones I respect.
6. I keep meticulous notes I'd rather die than let anyone else read.

Ideals

1. The Line. Some things cross a line no circumstance excuses. I hold that line. (Lawful)
2. Necessary Evil. The Veil does ugly work so other people don't have to. I've made peace with that. (Evil)
3. Not All Monsters. The Veil paints with too broad a brush. I judge individuals, not species. (Good)
4. My Own Hunt. I use the Veil's resources for my own reasons, and I don't apologize for it. (Chaotic)

Bonds

1. My mentor in the Veil died on a hunt I walked away from. I owe that debt to someone.
2. There's a Veiled creature I was supposed to kill and didn't. That decision follows me.
3. The Veil saved someone I love from something monstrous. I'll never leave the order over it.
4. I'm quietly building a case against how the Veil operates, from the inside.

Flaws

1. I see threats in Veiled creatures that aren't actually there.
2. I've hidden things from the Veil that would get people I care about hunted.
3. I have a genuinely hard time trusting anyone who isn't also a hunter.
4. My professional detachment isn't as complete as I pretend it is.

Veiled-Touched

You didn't grow up hiding from monsters. You grew up next to them — in a village under a witches' coven's protection, or in the shadow of a vampire lord's realm, close enough to know the difference between the stories people tell about the Veiled and the actual people living behind them.

Skill Proficiencies: Insight, and your choice of Persuasion or Deception

Languages: One language associated with a Veiled community (work with your DM — Necril, Sylvan, or similar)

Equipment: A protective charm or token from your home community, a set of traveler's clothes, and 10 gp

Feature — Old Neighbors. Veiled creatures and communities you approach in good faith are inclined to give you the benefit of the doubt before anyone else — you carry yourself like someone who was raised around them rather than someone hunting them, and that reads clearly to those with the senses to notice. This doesn't grant automatic trust, but it reliably earns you a conversation where an outsider might get a confrontation instead.

Personality Traits

1. I forget that most people find Veiled creatures frightening until I see their reaction.
2. I correct people, reflexively, when they get Veiled customs or etiquette wrong.
3. I'm fiercely protective of the community that raised me, even from people who mean well.
4. I read a room for the same tells my neighbors taught me to watch for — and it works on anyone.
5. I keep odd hours, on old habit, that don't match however I'm currently living.
6. I'm unfailingly polite to things other people would run from.

Ideals

1. Neither Monster Nor Saint. Everyone, Veiled or not, deserves to be judged as an individual. (Good)
2. The Old Ways. My home community's customs are worth defending, even against a changing world. (Lawful)
3. Between Worlds. I belong to both sides and neither, and I like it that way. (Chaotic)
4. Useful Distance. I keep one foot in each world because it's advantageous, not sentimental. (Neutral)

Bonds

1. The coven or lord who protected my home community is owed a debt I intend to pay.
2. I have a Veiled friend from home I still write to, when I can get word through.
3. My home community's safety depends on secrecy I've sworn to protect.

4. Someone from outside my community once tried to burn it down. I haven't forgotten their face.

Flaws

1. I underestimate how dangerous some Veiled creatures actually are, out of old familiarity.
2. I have little patience for people who fear the Veiled reflexively, and it shows.
3. I'll lie to protect my home community's secrets, even to people who deserve the truth.
4. I trust Veiled strangers faster than I trust ordinary people, which isn't always earned.

Island Hopper

The Era of Convergence turned the map into a thousand small worlds, and you decided the only sane response was to see as many of them as you could. You've bartered passage on a dozen different ships, slept in a dozen different customs, and learned that "normal" changes completely every time the coastline does.

Skill Proficiencies: Survival, and your choice of Nature or Perception

Tool Proficiencies: Navigator's tools or water vehicles

Equipment: A well-worn traveler's journal full of half-finished sketches and notes, a set of traveler's clothes suited for sea travel, and 10 gp

Feature — Chart of a Hundred Shores. Between the routes you've sailed, the sailors you've bartered with, and the sheer number of islands and pockets you've passed through, you can usually get a rough sense of direction and distance to the nearest known settlement even in unfamiliar waters, and you can typically talk your way onto a ship's crew or cargo hold for cheap — or free, if you're willing to work the passage.

Personality Traits

1. I compare literally everything to somewhere else I've been.
2. I strike up conversations with strangers immediately, out of pure habit.
3. I've picked up a dozen small customs from a dozen places and mix them without noticing.
4. I get restless fast if I stay anywhere longer than a couple weeks.
5. I collect one small object from every place I visit — no exceptions.
6. I tell stories in a way that makes even boring days sound like adventures.

Ideals

1. The Whole Map. The Convergence made the world huge again. I intend to see all of it. (Chaotic)
2. Bridges, Not Borders. Every pocket I visit, I try to leave a little more connected to the next. (Good)
3. Profit in Passage. I know things and places other people don't. That's worth something. (Neutral)
4. Nowhere Is Home. Roots are a liability. I keep moving on principle. (Neutral)

Bonds

1. There's one island or pocket I never finished exploring, and it nags at me.
2. A captain who took me on as crew when I had nothing gets my loyalty for life.
3. I'm searching for a place I heard about once and haven't been able to find again.
4. Someone I traveled with is still out there somewhere, and I intend to cross paths again.

Flaws

1. I romanticize places I've barely spent any real time in.

2. I have a bad habit of leaving right when things start to matter.
3. I'll take a risky passage or shortcut just because it's a route I haven't tried.
4. I've told the same exaggerated story about myself in enough ports that I'm not sure what's true anymore.